

Grade 1 Neurodiversity Lesson Plans by Cocoon Corner

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Stanford Neurodiversity Project

Neurodiversity Concept

Time: 40 minutes

Day 1

- Core Message: "Neurodiversity means that all our brains are different."
- Summary: Introduces neurodiversity using Aaron Slater, Illustrator. Students explore unique thinking styles through a interactive movement game and create personalized paper brain art highlighting their individual strengths.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / Screen & Audio (to display the human body diagram visual)
2. Whiteboard + Markers (for writing and practicing the pronunciation of neurodiversity)
3. Paper Brain Art Worksheet (1 copy per student)
4. Crayons / Markers / Colored Pencils
5. Scissors (1 pair per student to cut out paper brains)

Would-you-rather movement activity (10 mins)

Start with a fun **would-you-rather activity**, done in an area of the classroom where **kids can move around** (such as a rug or a furniture-free section).

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- The instructor will ask a question with two options (examples below).
- Next, the instructor will tell the kids, "Stand over here if you prefer [option 1], and stand over here if you prefer [option 2]. Stand in the middle if you can't decide."
- Make sure students do not change answers or become peer-pressured by friends—the difference is big!. Once the students have settled, ask a few kids from different areas to explain their choice to the class.

Below is the complete list of questions. Feel free to modify the questions as appropriate.

- Would you rather always whisper or always shout?
- Would you rather eat broccoli-flavored ice cream or pickle-flavored cake?
- Would you rather play outside all day or inside all day?
- Would you rather play with a big group or one best friend?
- Would you rather have a giant pet hamster or a tiny pet elephant?
- Would you rather eat only one color of food or wear only one color of clothes?
- Would you rather sing on stage or watch from the audience?



Day 1 cont.

All-Class Discussion & Brain Concept (15 mins)	2 Next, the class will transition into an all-class discussion, following the structure below: • Did we all have the same answers to every question? ◦ Likely answer: No • Why did we all have different answers? Display the cartoon diagram of a human body here or <i>draw</i> it on the board. It shows a stomach, a foot, an eye, and a brain: • These are all parts of our body. Which part of our body helps us make our decisions? ◦ Answer: The brain! • Do you think that all of our brains are the same or that they're all different? ◦ Answer: All brains are different! Say: Did you know that there's a word for all our brains being different? It's called 'neurodiversity'. Write the word on the board and help the kids pronounce it. If needed, ask kids to repeat their definition of neurodiversity to the class.
Paper Brain Art Activity (15 mins)	3 Worksheet for art activity attached here • Explain to students that they will decorate paper brains with features that make their brains unique. • For example, if a student likes dogs, playing softball, and the color green, they could draw a dog and a softball and shade the background green. • Once the kids have colored in their brains, distribute scissors so they can cut them out. • These brains can either be sent home with them or be hung up as a classroom wall display (perhaps with a sign captioning the display with "Neurodiversity is beautiful!")



Equality & Fairness

Time: 40 minutes

Day 2

- Core Message: Fairness means that everyone gets what they need, not the exact same thing.
- Summary: Explore equity versus equality using the short film *How Kids Make Things Fair*. Students work in pairs on recess scenario cards to practice finding fair solutions to everyday playground challenges.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play the Fair is Fair by Sonny Varela storybook video) or purchase book
2. Sorting Scenario Cards (1 set per pair/group; MUST BE PRECUT ALONG LINES)

Warm-Up Check-In: Same vs. Need (10 mins)

Begin with questions:

- If one person is cold, should everyone wear a jacket?
- If one person can't see the board, should everyone get glasses?
- If one person is hungry, should we all eat again?

Have students answer these questions and transition to introducing the topic of needs and equality in neurodivergence. Display the fence image attached to the slideshow.

- Sometimes giving everyone the SAME thing isn't actually fair.
- FAIR means giving everyone what they NEED.
- Link to Day 1 lesson: Some people need different things to learn or feel comfortable because we all have different brains.

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Read storybook (10 mins)

Play: Fair is Fair by Sonny Varela

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Game: Fair or Not Fair? (10 mins)

Game: Fair or not Fair?

- Hare gets a handful of food, Giraffe gets a wheelbarrow of food, and Elephant gets a truckload of food.
 - Fair
- Hare, Giraffe, and Elephant each get a wheelbarrow of food.
 - Not fair
- Giraffe gets a tall water bucket, and Hare gets a short water bowl.
 - Fair
- A kid who can't see the board gets glasses.
 - Fair

3



	4 • Everyone gets the same size shoes. ◦ Not fair • A kid who takes longer to finish worksheets gets more time to finish her worksheet. ◦ Fair • Everyone gets the same amount of time to finish their worksheet. ◦ Not fair What does fairness mean?
Sorting Activity (10 mins)	5 Students get to use what they've learned about fairness and equality in this hands-on competition. • Divide kids into groups of 4-5. • Each group will receive one set of sorting cards, linked here. Pass out the cards face-down. • Hand out <u>one sorting structure page</u> to each group. Review the significance of each quadrant with the class. • Each group will sort the graphics into their appropriate quadrant on the sorting worksheet. If desired, this can be competitive – the first group to CORRECTLY sort their photos wins bragging rights. <u>Answer key linked here.</u> • Countdown from ten. At the end of the countdown, kids may flip over their cards and begin.



Day 3

- Core Message: Understanding direct communication and literal language.
- Summary: Uses Amelia Bedelia to examine literal language and autistic communication styles. Students collaborate to rewrite indirect instructions into direct phrasing and design key-takeaway bookmarks.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play the [Amelia Bedelia: First Day of School by Herman Parish storybook video](#)) or purchase book
2. [Rewrite Worksheet](#) **OR** Whiteboard + Markers (for teacher-guided "Rewrite" direct phrasing practice)
3. [Bookmark Activity Worksheet](#) (1 copy per student)
4. Crayons / Markers / Colored Pencils
5. Scissors (1 pair per student to cut out bookmarks)

"Rewrite Group Exercise (15 mins)"

- Begin the lesson with a read-aloud of **Amelia Bedelia: First Day of School** **1**
by Herman Parish.
- If the classroom already owns this book, the instructor can read it aloud. If not, the linked video can be played.
 - This book introduces literal communication, a common indicator of autism!

Guided Class Discussion (10 mins)

Discuss as a class (select 3-4):

- What was your favorite part or silly mix-up of the story?
- "What could Miss Edwards have done differently to help Amelia Bedelia understand what she *actually* meant?"
- What could Amelia Bedelia have done if she wasn't sure what the directions meant?
- If you were Amelia Bedelia's classmate, how could you help her understand?
- What can we do when someone communicates differently from us?

"Rewrite Group Exercise (15 mins)"

- Rewrite the list of commands in words Amelia would understand ("time to jump off" "you're my last tag"), showing how precise language prevents confusion.
- Do this as a class on the board or using **this worksheet**

Bookmark Activity Worksheet (10 mins)

Make your own bookmark activity worksheet!



Applying Concepts

Time: 40 minutes

Day 4

- Core Message: Empathizing with differences and supporting peers.
- Summary: Uses the animated short film *Falling Letters* to explore sensory processing, focus, and neurodivergent perspectives in the classroom. Students then work in small groups to play a scenario-based game, synthesizing key concepts of fairness, direct communication, and empathy from throughout the week.

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play the [Growing Up Neurodivergent: "Falling Letters" video](#))
2. [Scenario Game Slideshow](#) & [Script](#) (to display scenario slides and read discussion prompts)
3. Scenario Answer Key (printed or digital copy for teacher reference during group discussions)

Film Viewing (10 mins)

Watch Video: *Growing up Neurodivergent ("Falling Letters")*.

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- This video is an introduction to neurodivergence
- It has a focus on ADHD, but includes traits common to all forms of neurodivergence.
- You may show twice, pausing for questions to increase comprehension.

Discussion Questions (20 mins)

Think-Pair-Share Discussion Questions:

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1. What happens to the letters and numbers when the boy tries to read or focus?
 - a. What does he create instead?
2. What did the boy do with the school lunch food?
 - a. What does he create instead?
3. What did the boy create during his math lesson?
 - a. How cool is that flipbook that he made?
4. At the end of the film, how did things change when a caring adult/person supported him?
5. What is something amazing about how the boy's brain works?



Day 4 cont.

Scenarios for Applying Concepts (20 mins)

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- This scenario game will help students synthesize the information that they have learned in the past three days.
- The instructor will display **this** slideshow for the class, and then read scenarios and discussion questions from a script.
 - The script is in the speaker notes of the slideshow and linked **here**—either works as long as the instructor can read the script and the class can simultaneously view the slideshow.
- Divide students into discussion groups of 3-4.
- Read the first scenario to the entire class.
- Read the question to the class, and let kids discuss in their groups for 1-3 minutes.
- Pull the class together again and ask a few groups to share out.
- Repeat for the remainder of the scenarios.
- The correct resolution for each scenario should be clear, but if confusion arises, the answer key is below:

Scenario 1: Charlie's accommodations are not equal, but fair because he *needs* the extra time to finish his worksheet.

Scenario 2: Neither were trying to be mean. Jacob and Amelia should explain their side of the conflict to each other.

Scenario 3: It's okay that Eve's preferences are different from her classmates'! Neurodiversity is fun and beautiful.

Scenario 4: Camila didn't intend to ruin Noah's sand castle.



Day 5

- Core Message: Pledging inclusion and celebrating classroom diversity.
- Summary: Reviews weekly takeaways to co-create inclusive classroom expectations. Students decorate individual hexagon tiles highlighting kindness and unity to build a collective "Kindness Wall."

Summary

Materials

1. Projector / TV & Audio (to play the [Aaron Slater, Illustrator by Andrea Beaty storybook video](#)) or physical book
2. [Hexagon Tile / Kindness Wall Worksheet](#) (1 copy per student)
3. Crayons / Markers / Colored Pencils
4. Scissors (1 pair per student to cut out hexagon tiles for the Kindness Wall)

Weekly Recap & Reflection (10 mins)

Say: "To start today, we're going to see what we remember from this week's neurodiversity lessons!" Ask the following questions:

- What does "neurodiversity" mean?
 - All brains are different
- Does "being fair" mean giving everyone the same thing, or different things?
 - Fair means giving everyone what they NEED, not giving everyone the SAME thing.
- Does everybody communicate in the same way?
 - No!

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Read-Aloud / Video (10 mins)

Aaron Slater, Illustrator by Andrea Beaty—a book about dyslexia (8:00).

2

Discussion questions:

- What do you think Aaron loves to do? What tools is he holding?
- Who here loves to draw, paint, or make things? How does it feel when you are creating something?
- How do Aaron's drawings tell a story even without using any written words?

Connection to neurodiversity discussion questions:

- Reading words is tricky for Aaron's brain. What is something his brain is completely amazing at?
- Does having a hard time reading mean Aaron isn't smart, or does it mean his brain is different, just like how all our brains are different?



Day 5 cont.

Creating Classroom Guidelines / Pledge (10 mins)	Creating Classroom Guidelines/Pledge 3 • At the start of the year, many classrooms create their classroom guidelines • As a class, come up with some (more) class guidelines that facilitate the following and more ◦ Equality and fairness ◦ Inclusion ◦ Respect ◦ Communication and accepting differences ◦ Ideas about neurodiversity and differences & how to be accepting of all different kinds of brains
The Kindness Wall / Personal Hexagon Activity (20 mins)	The Kindness Wall/Personal Hexagon - worksheet attached here 4 • Each student will decorate a hexagon with a picture representing kindness, inclusion, love, and related themes. ◦ Directions: Draw a picture of one kind thing you can do for someone. ◦ Teacher may change directions • <i>OR: Students can decorate it as a truly personal hexagon and include things they like/things about themselves on it</i>